



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with NO

Anonymous (NO)

21st May 2019

Location of interview: Queen's University Belfast

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Pete Hodson

Warning this transcript contains details of sexual abuse.

NO was placed in one of the Good Shepherd mother and baby homes in Northern Ireland when she became pregnant as a teenager. This was during the 1980s. She describes the process through which her baby son was taken for adoption, explaining that this was not what she wanted. NO reveals the efforts she made to try and keep him, which included writing a positive letter to the Good Shepherd Sisters about her time in the home, in the hope that they would intercede on her behalf to prevent the baby's adoption. The interview details the trauma caused by his adoption. There is also traumatic testimony in relation to her treatment while she was in the home, including details about sexual abuse that occurred there and earlier in NO's life. Names and locations are redacted to offer anonymity to NO and to her family. Redactions are indicated by **

OD: OK. So just for the tape, my name is Olivia Dee and we are in my office at Queen's University. I'm here with an anonymous interviewee who's going to tell me about her experience of *Good Shepherd mother and baby home? Yep? And it is the 21st of May 2019. OK, so, just for your own kind of peace of mind – we don't use any names. If you use a name, we'll take it out of the transcript

so don't worry about that – and I won't identify you or anything. We've already, sort of, had a look through some of the documents that you have? But I wanted to just ask you, first of all, what your connection is with *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, you know, why did you go there? How old were you? All the things that we sort of previously discussed? Just for the tape.

NO: Yep. I went to ... I was at home living in my mother's house – my father was dead at the time. And whenever she found out I was pregnant, she rang the priest and the social worker and the doctor – and they all came out to the house. They were, like, discussing my whole life in the kitchen, and I was closed in the living room. And the next thing I knew, I was going away with this woman that I didn't know.

OD: And was she the social worker?

NO: Uhuh. But I remember her name – she was *name redacted* And I was took to *location redacted* – never been in *location redacted* in my whole life – and she brought me down to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. And that's where I met ... I only ever really remember Sister Q – was a big, tall woman – and Sister R – was a wee, tiny woman – and Sister Z, I think, was the boss. I just remember being left there and absolutely hating it, you know, closed in a wee small room on your own. Never had any clothes of my own. I wore someone else's clothes all the time. If you were six months pregnant, and then you got eight months pregnant – you wore someone else's...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... outfit. And I didn't think the nuns were very nice, to be honest. Whenever I...they would have made you do chores all the time? And I

remember learning how to knit, and they would rush you to the Mass – all of that kind of thing. And there was like an oratory? Like a chapel, in the place? And Sister Z, she used to march us away down there every day. And during the knitting, we'd be knitting or doing something. But I remember whenever I was about eight months pregnant, that they made you clean the stairs. Up the stairs and down the stairs. And I know, the day, that that was to induce your labour. And I remember having a horrible experience with them, where I was in my room and didn't know what was wrong with me, like. I was really bad, in pain, and came out of the room and walked this big, long corridor, and I remember rapping her door where she was. She came out and she says: "What is wrong with you?" And I says: "I don't know whether I'm going to have this baby or not". And she put me up on a couch and – to my knowledge now – she gave me an internal and said: "Go back to bed, you stupid girl". And just put me out of her office, and I went back out of the room crying...

OD: Would you like me to stop?

[Recording paused at this point because NO was upset]

[Interview recommences]

OD: ... the tape there, OK. So, obviously, some of the stuff you're talking about is going to make you incredibly emotional or upset – and we're completely fine with stopping the tape, or if you just need a moment you can just tell me.

NO: Yeah.

OD: So can I just ask you a couple of things about what you said before? So how old were you? You said you were sixteen?

NO: I was sixteen when I got pregnant, but when went into the home I was seventeen. I'd just turned seventeen in *month redacted*.

OD: OK. And were the circumstances around your pregnancy...were you sort of surprised to find yourself pregnant? Was it something that you weren't quite sure how it happened, or ...? Did you have a boyfriend?

NO: No, I was running about with this boy at the time and we really were only children. And my father had died, and his father had died. We used to just go to children's discos and stuff, and maybe take drink before we'd go into it, you know?

OD: So like normal teenager stuff?

NO: Cans of beer. And then I remember my first experience ever really drunk. It would've been one night, we decided to go the *location redacted*, and we didn't tell anyone we were going. But I just remember waking up – and my mother was always really cross – and I always thought that from [when] my father died, I suppose, maybe, I didn't really get on that well with her. And she went mad about this boy because he was a Protestant and I was a Catholic.

OD: Oh, OK.

NO: All that just went on. She went on and on about that all the time. And I ran away, anyway, to the *location redacted* and I was afraid to go home and woke up in a hay shed like, maybe, a mile from the house. And didn't know I was pregnant.

OD: Yeah.

NO: First time in my life ever had sex ...

OD: And you got pregnant?

NO: ...I remember being at school – I was still at school – and I didn't tell anyone, only my sister. I was telling her one day, I was like a real good ... and we were sitting outside and my mummy was in the back of the field emptying ashes, and she came up and she started to kick me round the place. And it wasn't long after that she sent me away ...

OD: How many months were you when you...?

NO: I was about five months.

OD: OK. So that must have been really frightening, like, I've been sixteen anyway ... and just doing normal teenage things...

NO: And I remember crying to her and saying: "Please let me stay at home for my birthday" – because my birthday was on the *date redacted*. And I says: "I just want to stay at home" and I remember crying and crying and crying. But mummy wouldn't listen to me at all, like, do you know? I just ... even 'til this day I hate whenever you're trying to say something to somebody and they won't listen to you. It just affects me real bad, like.

OD: Yeah. And do you think that your mum was sending you away because she didn't want people to see you pregnant? Or was it, was it more because she felt like it would be better for you to be...

NO: No, I think...She used to say to me I brought shame on the family and everything. And I suppose I grew up a lot of my life thinking she hated me, too. Do you know, with all that?

OD: And how does that feeling of shame, kind of ... does it come with you through your whole life? Because ...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...being told that at sixteen must have been so...And how do you come to terms, you know, realising that you didn't do anything wrong and...

NO: Yeah. I used to blame myself all the time and, I suppose, my whole life after that I just turned to drink and I would have drank a lot.

OD: OK.

NO: I never really realised how ... It's a ... Like whenever my mother wanted him adopted and all, I just couldn't handle that at all, and took an overdose and I ended up in the clinic in *location redacted* for about six or seven weeks. And I came out of there and never went home. I just got a house on my own and thought if I got a job I'd get the baby back.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And I'd be able to keep him and ... All of the time, in my heart, I just wanted him. But it didn't work out that way.

OD: So you're in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and you know you're pregnant, and you're kind of doing these daily routines and these cleanings – and you said the stairs was to try and induce you?

NO: Yeah. I think that's what it was about.

OD: So something...

NO: It's only when you grow up that you realise...

OD: ...yeah. That you can see things like that?

NO: ...you know? Because I remember being so tired and Sister Z and them shouting away: "Get up and clean them stairs". Just making you go up and down, and up and down the stairs all the time.

OD: At eight months?

NO: Yeah.

OD: Wow! So what do you sort of remember about those nuns, specifically? Is there anything that you kind of remember?

NO: I see Sister Z's face every time I go to bed. She's just ... she just real cross. I have a photograph of her, with my baby, in my bag. Just if I look at it, I always think she ... if I think about her, I just know she wasn't a nice person, like. None of them probably were. But I always remember her the most.... To me, I would have thought she was like the boss of them all.

OD: OK.

NO: But I don't know if I was right or not. She just seemed to do all the marching about and taking you from one place to another. And if you were happy sitting talking to somebody, she's move you or tell you to do something else.

OD: So they didn't want you to be friends with anyone, or ...?

NO: Not really.

OD: OK. And did you, could you tell people who you were and where you came from, and what your story was? Or ...?

NO: Well, I remember all the girls that was in it. I remember their names, I remember their faces. Everything.

OD: And what year was this?

NO: *year in the 1980s redacted*.

OD: Yeah. OK. So when you say – you mentioned the internal examination that Sister Z gave you when you thought you were in, when you were kind of in labour?

NO: Yeah.

OD: Had you had medical care before that? Had she kind of given you

examinations ...?

NO: No.

OD: ... or anything? Or had anyone given you ...?

NO: No.

OD: OK. Had you been to a doctor, or anything when you were [t]here?

NO: No. I don't ever remember going to the doctors at all.

OD: OK. And did anyone talk to you about what to expect?

NO: No.

OD: So labour must have been quite terrifying for you?

NO: I hadn't a clue.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Hadn't a clue what was going on.

OD: So the night, the night you felt what you thought were labour pains and you went to Sister Z, what exactly did she say to you? Because she said ...

NO: Well that time I went into the room and rapped the door she was shouting out through the door at me: "Who is it? Who is it?" And when I went into her,

she says: “Why are you up? Why are you out of bed?” And “Why are you not in your room?” And I remember saying to her that I thought I was going to have the baby. She brought me into another room – I think it was another room, as far as I remember – and told me to take off my clothes, and she gave me an internal.

OD: All your clothes?

NO: My bottom part.

OD: OK. And she gave you an internal examination?

NO: Yeah.

OD: OK.

NO: And then she told me to just ... she says: “You’re a very, very stupid girl” and “Go away back to your room”. And I remember leaving her office and crying, literally, the whole way back to my room and just lying there crying.

OD: Was that because of how she’d made you feel?

NO: Well I really had nobody in my life.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Because my mother never contacted me all in that whole space of time. And I had, like, an older sister that would have come down on the bus from the home to see me, and that was the only time you ever got out. It was like bars on

the door. And you were really locked up all day. The only time I ever remember going out was when my sisters called – I think I was allowed out with them for an hour.

OD: Wow.

NO: All in one day they used to parade us up to the the Post Office ... And we had, like, a book? Like a pension book?

OD: Right, yeah.

NO: And the money that we got, whatever money we got we only had like £6 for ourselves. If you wanted to buy cigarettes, you just kinda sneaked them and ...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ...but that was all you really had, you know, all the rest of the money they would have took.

OD: Oh, so you would have given them...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...your benefit?

NO: They would have took us to the Post Office.

OD: Right. And then given you, like, some pocket money and then...

NO: And that was it.

OD: So you must have been so lonely?

NO: Oh, I didn't see my mother. But I remember one of my sisters, she came down for the first time ... and I hated the clothes, oh. Hated the clothes and hated the shoes. They gave you these wee flat shoes and horrible dresses.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Big, white dresses. And my sister that did never come down, came down one day, and the nuns – they'd have to ring the bell outside and the nun would answer the door – and my sister looked at me and she says: "I couldn't walk up the street with you, love, looking like that". So then the nun would just close the door each time – "You're not having your visit today". And I would just go back into the room.

OD: That must have made you feel so small? Like, and so ... That's horrible.

NO: I don't think I would ever forget that part of my life, ever because it has haunted me all my life, and sometimes I find it just hard to even talk because I kind of re-live it all.

OD: Yeah.

NO: But I know it has left, like, mental scars in me that'll never, ever go away. Indeed they'll not.

OD: I think I'm really glad that you are talking about it. Because I want it to be included in this, but I also think, you know, you deserve to talk about it and you deserve to recognise that you didn't do anything wrong.

NO: Yeah.

OD: And that, you know, perhaps if, you know, if you can talk about it then more people will be able to explain that, you know. That feeling of shame is not your fault – that's something that people said, and it was incredibly wrong.

NO: I just know, like, two of my sisters saw the baby when he was born, and the father of the child came down to visit me too. And he saw the child, and the rest of my sisters just called me a tramp ...

OD: For doing something that's so common? Getting pregnant at that age is so common? Nothing to be ashamed of. Sorry – use as many as you want [giving NO more tissues]. So, then, I suppose the next part that I'm interested in, I mean you've done a really good job at sort of explaining why, why the place was cold and made you feel ashamed and all the kind of things like that. Were you ... So you've given us some notes about your time there that was given to – that were given to you – by Family Care [the Family Care Society].

NO: Yeah.

OD: And in the notes it says that you were adamant that you wanted to keep the baby.

NO: Yeah.

OD: So how did you, how did you kind of express that? Did you just refuse to talk about ...

NO: I remember when I had the baby in the hospital, and they wanted to take him into the wee nursery at night – I wouldn't let them take him. I just kept him in my room all the time.

OD: Yeah. So you must ... It says here [referring to paperwork that NO brought with her] that you had a slightly difficult birth.

NO: Yeah.

OD: So was that ...

NO: I was in the hospital for a week or more.

OD: Wow. And you had stitches ...

NO: Nearly two weeks I think, yeah.

OD: OK, so did anyone kind of talk you through what had happened?

NO: No.

OD: No. So it was just a difficult ...

NO: I remember my mum coming down with this social worker.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And me crying and asking her to hold the baby, and she didn't want to.

OD: Yeah.

NO: She didn't even want to look at him. But eventually she did hold him. But just, like, for a second.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Because ...

OD: So were you hoping that if she held him that she would want to keep ...

NO: Yeah.

OD: Yeah. So it says here that most babies were put into foster care when you were discharged? Was that the case with you?

NO: My mother had said to me that I wasn't allowed to come home with the baby – that I could come home if the baby wasn't with me.

OD: Right.

NO: But I found out that my child was in foster care in *location redacted* and I went to see him every day there.

OD: Oh, that's lovely.

NO: And fed him and wheeled him about.

OD: So you went home to your parent's – to your mother's – house?

NO: I didn't go home for a month, I think.

OD: Where did you stay?

NO: I was still in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*.

OD: So you stayed in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* after the birth?

NO: Yeah.

OD: And you went down to *foster home* every day?

NO: No, this was from when I went home to my mother's.

OD: OK, I'm really sorry, I couldn't quite understand. OK, so when you were still in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* your baby was in the nursery there?

NO: No, my baby was ... the day that I came out of the hospital, *name redacted*, the social worker, and my mother, came to the hospital and I actually was really happy thinking I was coming home with them.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And they brought me over to *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* and I thought well this is probably just me going in here saying goodbye.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And I had photographs taken of the other people that was in there, holding the child. And then I remember the social worker and my mother saying that I was wanted in the office, by the nun. And when I went down to the office and I came back – they were gone. And the baby was gone, from the home, from *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*. And I was just left there.

OD: Wow. And did the nun sort of explain to you what had happened?

NO: I don't ever remember the nun ever saying anything.

OD: So you were just expected to get right back to work, or?

NO: Yeah.

OD: So back into your routine cleaning and ...

NO: Yeah because we were given chores every day. You could have been doing the dishes or, you know, there was all these different things. But you always had to do stuff.

OD: And I can imagine after you've gone through that, first of all, a difficult birth, and second of all, your baby's gone and your mother's gone and you're back there. Did you know how long you were gonna be there for?

NO: No.

OD: That must have been really frightening.

NO: I never felt as lost in my life.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Because I remember it all. I just remember everything about it.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Because I remember going home and the woman that had him fostered was called Mrs *name redacted*, from *location redacted*, and I would go to her house. She was a big woman with blonde hair and she would bring me in and I would talk and ... [there are] photographs of me feeding the child and everything. And I remember one day going to her house, and she told me that the child was adopted and was no longer there. But I remember my mother taking me to some place in *location redacted*. I got a job, and I remember thinking if I could just get a house ... The child's father, his mother, was really good to me ...

OD: Yeah, good.

NO: ... and his father had died, but the mother was very good to me. And she said that, you know, I could come and stay with her. And I was just fighting to get this baby back. The social worker used to come to where I worked and sit outside all the time and say to me: "You have to sign these papers. You have to sign these papers." Just, you know, just really hassling me all the time? All I

remember was I went into *location redacted* and there was some kind of a butchers. I remember a butchers, and we went in the back of the butchers and they made me sign these pages. And then when I went back to that woman's house, they said the child was adopted.

OD: Did you understand what those papers were?

NO: No.

OD: So ...

NO: I don't even remember signing the papers, but I remember being taken to the butchers – and I presume it was to sign some papers.

OD: Right. So the social worker used to come to your work every day?

NO: Yeah.

OD: To...

NO: And when I got a job – I got a job in a factory in *location redacted* – and I think it was a Friday, the social worker used to always turn up and hassle me about the child, and I would come out crying saying to her: “This is not what I want. You know?” And she says: “Well, you don't have any choice and you're not eighteen. Your mother doesn't want you to bring this baby home” and “Where are you gonna go?” At that time the child's father – or, mother – said she would help me, and she took cancer and she died.

OD: So you just lost your kind of support? So I'm just wondering, then, why ...

what the papers were and why they had you sign them...

NO: I don't know. You see, I don't know if it was papers, but I know I went into this butchers and at the back of the butchers there was something, and I was taken in there. And I don't know if it was to sign papers or what.

OD: So what do you think made you – if you did sign them – what do you think would have made you finally sign something?

NO: I just think that all the time my mother just went on and on and on.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And the social workers...

OD: So...

NO: ... nobody was there to help me do what I wanted to do.

OD: There was so much pressure I can't even imagine...

NO: I just vaguely remember. I don't even really remember signing the papers, but I remember going to that place.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And I presume that's where they must have made me sign the papers.

OD: Well, if afterwards the baby was adopted that would suggest that.

NO: Yeah.

OD: But you still turned up to the foster mother and...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ... expected to see the baby?

NO: Because I remember the day that I knew that he was gone. And I came down from our house and I walked out in front of cars and lorries and everything – and I did not care if somebody had drove over me and killed me.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And I ended up in *hospital redacted* and I didn't want to see nobody. Didn't want to see any of my family at all.

OD: How did you end up in the ward?

NO: Sorry?

OD: How did you end up in in the ward?

NO: That was in, like, a mental hospital. Because I then went home and ... They'd give me anti-depressant tablets and stuff. I think they probably knew all along what the outcome was going to be – and I never knew. And I took an overdose.

OD: Wow!

NO: And I was brought to *location redacted*, and I stayed for six or seven weeks. I never went home after that – at all, ever.

OD: So you just got your own place? How did you manage that, was it...

NO: Well my sister was living in a place, and then I went and stayed in her house and then we – she – just must have discussed it with me, having a baby and all. And I remember she moved out and I just kept the house.

OD: OK. And did you go back to work in the same...?

NO: Yeah. Mhmm.

OD: Yeah.

NO: I worked in that factory for a long time.

OD: How was the treatment? What was the treatment like in 1980s for something like an overdose? Did anyone ask you why you had done something like that?

NO: I just think they thought: give you a few anti-depressants and you'd be OK.

OD: Yeah.

NO: But I remember lying there, and it was the most probably scariest experience of my life. I remember a woman, an oldish woman with white hair,

and she was walking around and she was pulling her hair. She was pulling lumps out of her hair. And she kept saying: "The time in June. The time in June." I remember it like yesterday, I swear to God. But I remember I'd get into the bed and it was like cubicles? And I would just pull the whole clothes over my head. It was frightening. Really scary.

OD: I suppose you didn't know how long you were gonna be there either?

NO: No.

OD: And no one, no one kind of talked to you about the trauma of giving your baby away, or anything like that? Or why you may have done this, or ...?

NO: No.

OD: So you were just treated like another patient?

NO: Yeah. I just used to cry all the time, just real sad.

OD: Yeah. And did you kind of understand, then, that it would be more difficult to get your baby? Like, that that wasn't going to be an option anymore, or ...?

NO: I just actually thought my life was just over.

OD: Yeah.

NO: I honestly did. And, I suppose, part of me wanted it to be over, because I didn't really think there was anything in life to live for, really. For a long time I used to think, my father was killed on the road, and my brother next to me was

killed on the road, and then I had this baby. I believe it was the only thing in my life that I'd ever loved – well, after my father and brother was dead, because I didn't have a relationship with my mother because of the pregnancy. And I just thought well, if he's taken away there's nobody really left to love – and that'll love me back. And I guess I've just grew up all my life feeling really unwanted, and all of ... You know, I look back at my life now – because there was so many times I would've drank and wanted to end my life. Hated it when the child's birthday would come and I couldn't see them.

OD: Yeah.

NO: I would've got real drunk and walked to my mother's and fucked her up and down, and told her that she ruined my life and I hated her. But inside I was really hurting...

OD: Yeah, I can tell.

NO: And then I would pretend to the outside world that there was nothing wrong, and I can handle anything and ... Inside I was really broken. Really broken.

OD: Yeah.

NO: I suppose hindsight is a wonderful thing because you can look back, but...

OD: It is, but why would you ever know that at the time? That's ... To me, sixteen is such an important time...

NO: I just felt that I had no one in my life.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Nobody to turn to. Nobody to talk to.

OD: Yeah.

NO: I just felt really lost, you know? I went to counsellors and I remember one counsellor saying to me, you know: “What do you think’s wrong with your life?” And he says to me: “You know, you made all the decisions yourself and you never really had anyone to look up to, to say whether you were doing right or wrong”. And I know that to be true up to this day. Everything I did. But no matter what sort of relationship I was in, I don’t believe I was ever really happy.

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know? Because I was always ... My life, to me, is always like a big jigsaw puzzle with a big openness in the middle.

OD: Yeah. And it was missing from when you were sixteen, so that’s a formative time, I think ... Well, being a teenage girl anyway is so difficult and you don’t have that support and you go through something that is incredibly traumatic and you don’t have that support. And you do everything you can to keep that, that one thing in your life – and that’s taken away from you. I mean, I think you’ve done amazingly well to kind of push through that.

NO: I just find it so difficult sometimes.

OD: Yeah, I’m not surprised.

NO: And I think, you know, people, people have talked to me in their life, you know, would have said: “Oh, I understand how you feel”. But I know that people ... I don’t understand something that I haven’t experienced. So I know that other people don’t. They can have empathy with you, whatever, but they don’t really understand the pain of it all, so.

OD: Mhmm. Definitely.

NO: I just, I just find it really, really hard.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Because they would have told me ... I have two children, and my marriage broke-up because my husband had an affair when my daughter was nine months, and my son was two. I just struggled with all that too, and...

OD: Yeah.

NO: But I’ve told my children from a real young age about *name of adopted son redacted*, and I have a picture of him. They’ve seen loads of pictures of him that I have. [I] never would live a lie to them.

OD: No. Good.

NO: They know all about him. And I always had this thing that ... I suppose I always live in hope and thought when he’d be eighteen, he might come and look for me. I suppose I had all my hopes built up about it, when he was twenty-one he’d come – all that. It’s like I know I have to accept the way that things are, but

I just, I dunno, live in hope every day that one day I would meet him. And I have to understand that he's not that wee baby that I was holding, that he's a big man now.

OD: So he was born in 198*?

NO: *age redacted* now.

OD: OK. And have you ever tried to look for him?

NO: Yeah. Loads of times.

OD: And has that been difficult?

NO: See, social workers would come out...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... and then they would chat and they would say: "Oh, we'll do our best to try and trace him" or whatever. And they would go away, and they wouldn't even contact you. And I used to really hate it, because it was like ... One time a social worker said, well, I would ring her up and say: "Any word, or any news – or anything?" And told me one time to write a letter. And I wrote a letter explaining, you know, that I never ever wanted to give him away, that my mother had him adopted and stuff like that. And I remember the only two people I could read the letter to was my children, and they were only like – God, I think *son's name redacted* might have been nine, and *daughter's name redacted* was seven ...

OD: Yeah.

NO: And, sure, they wouldn't really have understood, do you know? But I remember saying to *son's name redacted*: "If you got a letter like that, *son's name redacted*, what would you think?" And he says: "I'd just think it was lovely" – but sure, he was only a wee child.

OD: Yeah.

NO: I was, like, talking to my son as if he was a grown-up.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Do you know? But I turned to drink my whole life after that, and my life just fell apart and ... I stopped drinking eighteen years ago.

OD: Well done.

NO: I've drank once in eighteen years. The pain never went away, like.

OD: I mean well done for stopping. I can't, I can imagine it's something ... that it's like a crutch that you would have used – but I think it's amazing that you stopped?

NO: I think it was fear, you know, that I would look at my children and think, my God. You see, my ex-husband went to report me to a social worker one time for drinking, and the social worker that came out was really angry. Oh, she was wicked as anything. I just thought, you know, my husband at that time, I suppose I hated him because he had hurt me and I thought: 'Is he going to take

these children away from me?’ Like I fought real hard to just try and stop drinking. I wasn’t able to manage that by myself and...

OD: Because it’s an addiction?

NO: Yeah. And I went to the Alcohol Unit in *location redacted*. But I went in and out of *name of unit redacted* – that ward that I had went in from taking the overdose. I would go out and I would, I suppose, pretend to people I was happy and end up in the clinic.

OD: Yeah, of course.

NO: Do you know? Because I would drink myself into an awful state, you know, that...I wasn’t coping, like I know I wasn’t coping.

OD: But you’ve done eighteen years?

NO: Yeah.

OD: That’s amazing. And do your kids support you through...?

NO: Yeah. I go to the A.A. [Alcoholics Anonymous] meetings and all now. They are real happy that I go there. Though I drank once in that whole time because...

OD: Once in eighteen years is amazing.

NO: ... the thing about me is when I would be in a relationship with someone ... I met someone ... I took cancer nine years ago and came through all of that.

One time I was really ill and I went into the hospital – it was supposed to be for a week, and I didn't come out of it for maybe nine or ten weeks. The only thing ... I really wasn't scared if I died, but I was all the time thinking I'd really like to see my son.

OD: Yeah.

NO: If it's gonna happen.

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know, I just know that's the way I felt. But I survived all that too.

OD: That's an incredible story. So what have been the main barriers, then, to you finding ... social workers ... you've just found the process difficult, or the...?

NO: *Name of social worker redacted* the woman from *location redacted*, would have wrote him a letter recently.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And then she told me that she would write him a letter to say she wanted to meet him?

OD: Yeah.

NO: And then I had said to her several times: "Would there be any chance I would even get a photograph?" You know? "Could you ask the adoptive parents

for a picture?" I says: "A picture would be better than nothing". And the last time I was talking to her, she said that she would write one more letter – but if she was doing that, it would be like her harassing him.

OD: OK.

NO: And that the law here, you can't just go and find your son.

OD: No, yeah.

NO: In Wales and England you can, and in the North of Ireland you can't.

OD: So you need to wait for him to...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ... decide that?

NO: One time, they told me he was at college, and he was doing really well, and the adoptive parents, their heart went out to me about wanting to find him. And then *social worker's name redacted* had wrote to me in a text saying "I sent the letter to him, recorded delivery, it didn't come back so he must have received it."

OD: OK.

NO: But she says: "I'll keep you posted if I hear anything – but if I keep writing to him, he can take me up for harassment".

OD: OK.

NO: But it's like, I start a thing and then it just stops.

OD: Yeah.

NO: It goes nowhere.

OD: It might just take time for him to...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...you know, come to ... you know?

NO: But I have been doing that since he was about ... First letter I wrote into the adoption agency that they said he'd find, oh God, it's a long time ago. My ... *name of second son redacted*, and I wrote that letter when he was about seven.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Seven, eight, nine.

OD: And you wrote this letter in 198* as well?

NO: Yeah.

OD: So can we talk a little bit about this letter? Because this one was right after ... So you wrote to Sister Z saying: 'Thank you, again, for the lovely time I had

in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home.*' What made you write that?

NO: Because I thought, because my mother was so down on me, I thought if I wrote a letter to them that they were nice to me, that they maybe would help me.

OD: So you sort of, you pretended that you'd had a good time?

NO: Yeah.

OD: Yeah. To get them to see you sympathetically and...

NO: Yeah.

OD: Yeah. See that's so difficult, isn't it, because this letter is so different to your memory of it? It must have ... You know, if someone read this...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...before they met you, they would think...

NO: Yeah, they'd think it was...

OD: ... it was completely different?

NO: They'd think ... they won't realise.

OD: Yeah. Because...

NO: But I remember thinking that they were the only people I could turn to...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ...that might be able to help me.

OD: Yeah. I can see that. So you decided to write, kind of, a letter praising, praising it and ... Yeah. And, so, this was your attempt to...

NO: Try and get him.

OD: ...try and get your baby back.

NO: Yeah. Because I only came out of *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* – it says on there, where I was discharged?

OD: Yeah.

NO: I think it was only the start of *date redacted*. And I had said in the letter, you know, that I'm going to see my son again on Thursday and I'm so looking forward to it...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... and can you just keep praying for me?

OD: I think that's really...

NO: But I definitely know that they were not nice.

OD: Yeah. I think the letter is really interesting because I'm wondering, you know ... It just makes, it makes ... it's two completely different side of things that when you meet you becomes so obvious why you would write that. It's very obvious that what's in that letter is a kind of desperate attempt to, to get your son.

NO: Yeah.

OD: I don't want to keep talking ... I really don't want to make you more upset...

NO: No, it's OK, it's alright. It's alright.

OD: OK. So I have a couple more questions, then, just about a couple of things that you mentioned in your ... when we were talking earlier. I just sort of jotted down a few notes that I was interested in. So, the first one was the way you speak about Sister Z, now, is ... you clearly have some quite strong, kind of, feelings around your experiences with the nuns there – and specifically Sister Z – and I was just wondering if you wanted to say any more about that? Was there anything else?

NO: I just think a lot of it was like abuse, because...

OD: OK.

NO: ... like I remember a cousin of my mum's abusing me when I was small. And I remember asking him to come to our house – we used to be sent to his house with, like, cakes and bread – and every time I went to that man's house he would abuse you, really bad. And, like, at the time he would have give us

money and stuff and you would have thought ... you wouldn't have knew...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... that it was abuse? And ... because I remember him dying of cancer, and my mother saying to me: "You need to go to his funeral", and me [thinking about] saying: "You don't know, fuck, how many times I've prayed that he would die" – but never said it to her. And she had said it to my sisters, at different times, two of my sisters: "Do you think *NO* would have been abused at one time?"

OD: Yeah.

NO: So...

OD: So you felt like that was a similar behaviour? ... And was that due to the kind of examination that you had?

NO: Yeah.

OD: It wasn't right?

NO: Because I remember crying and saying she was hurting me and all, and she says: "Just lie there, lie still, and keep quiet." I remember her talking to me like that.

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know? But she was not a nice person.

OD: And was there a chaperone or anyone with you?

NO: Nobody.

OD: Because you were quite young? OK.

NO: Because we had rooms in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* just like this [comparing it to the office space in which this interview took place]. Because I remember, when I stopped drinking, and it was exactly seventeen years later when I went into the Alcohol Unit in *location redacted*, and it was one room, one sink, and one cupboard. And it was the same in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home*, because I remember thinking ‘I am not staying here’. Because I was like, having really bad flashbacks from my life and...

OD: Yeah. Oh, that’s ... yeah. OK. I just wanted to give you a chance to, sort of, be honest about what you felt happened because I think it’s really important that you get to say that. OK. The other thing, then, I wanted to ask you about was when you’d left, and you’d went back to work and you stayed in your sister’s house and you stayed alone – did you have any kind of relationship with the father at that point? Or with your...

NO: Oh, yeah, we still spoke – and we still speak to the day.

OD: Yeah. Do you?

NO: Yeah.

OD: OK. And did you ever ... were you, sort of, back together or did you just

kind of...

NO: I think I just had no heart in anything, and really, at sixteen, what do you know? You know? About relationships. I guess I'll always care about him...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ...but, like he got married – he had two children first, and then he got married to a different girl who was friends with me. And then she stopped speaking to me, and she slapped me across the face one day on the street and said: “You know that he never owned the child” and everything, and I was just gutted. I didn't even swing at her or anything. I just bawled and cried in the street.

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know, so ... We would still talk. Like he would still message me and say: “I haven't seen you about in a long time – are you OK?” I suppose it is kind of strange, you know, the whole thing? Because I took cancer and whenever he was married to that girl, she would have ate the head of him if he looked out at me on the street.

OD: Yeah.

NO: “Why are you looking at that tramp?” – she would, that's what she would have said, because he told me. And they broke up, and then I was going to the hospital to get a cancer operation, and his brother was always really good friends with me – his brother's gay – and his brother had rang and said: “You know *name redacted* just wants to talk to you, *NO*, is it OK come see you?”

Or will you meet him somewhere?” And I said ... And I remember my mother and all at my house, and I just got into the car and left and went to the bottom of the road and met him. And he was in a wild state because his mother had died of cancer, and I was going to the hospital that evening for an operation the next morning, and he rang me up and he said: “When I was at the hospital then, my mother and all was crying on the street and everything, but it reminded me of going into the home and nobody giving a shite?” And I just said: “Why are you all crying?”

OD: Yeah.

NO: “I’m going to be fine”. And I left. And *name redacted* ran me to the hospital and he said: “Who’s going to be there for you in the morning when you’re going for your operation?” I said: “Oh, I’ll be fine. I’ll be OK”. And he drove all the way to *location redacted* and pushed my bed to the theatre.

OD: Wow.

NO: And that was, like, oh I dunno, twenty-something years later. So we never fell out, as in fell out.

OD: So you still had that connect ... because, I suppose, most people, you don’t have that lifelong connection with someone you knew when you were sixteen. And you got pushed together by this experience and, yeah.

NO: Because he would even write messages to me, because I would, I used to watch all the sad things about adoption and *Long Lost Families*...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... and I'd be crying. And there was one night there was a woman on it called *same name as interviewee* and her son was *same names as NO's first son*, and he [father of NO's first son] had wrote me a message saying: "Maybe one day, that will be you."

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know? And I would just sit there watching it and think why am I watching this? Because I knew rightly I was going to be, like, bawling crying – but I still watch it and think, maybe, one day, that will be me. And just praying and hoping that it will be.

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know? But we never lost contact at all.

OD: Good.

NO: Like it was only there on Saturday or Sunday, he texted and said: "I haven't seen you at the shop or anything – are you OK?" You know? Because when I took the cancer he was really worried, and then because his mother died of cancer, and then when I came through the cancer operation he took a heart attack – and his father had died of a heart attack.

OD: Oh.

NO: So it was like...

OD: So you guys have been a bit of support for each other over...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...all these years?

NO: But he would've said to me that I was the only person in his life he loved. And I remember, when I came out of the hospital after I had the cancer, I had said to my ex-husband can you just be here for the children? He basically just ran away, wasn't there at all, and *name redacted* came – this is the father of the first child – and I remember my daughter saying to me: “Why is he so good to us, when our daddy's not so good – or as good as him?” But I remember whenever he said to me that he still loved me, I said: “I'm sorry”, I says, “Every time I look at you I just see the child, and I just find it too difficult.” But we never, ever fell out.

OD: Good.

NO: Do you know?

OD: And is your relationship with your children good?

NO: Oh, really good.

OD: It's just stressed-out because of...

NO: No.

OD: ... OK. Good. And they look after you?

NO: Mhmm.

OD: Good.

NO: But my son is away at college, and *daughter's name redacted* is probably there all her life with me and is just like my best friend.

OD: Good. I'm really glad to hear that.

NO: You know?

OD: And if it, if or when, you do finally kind of manage to meet him I bet they'll be very supportive of you then, as well?

NO: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

OD: I'm really glad that you've been able to be honest with them...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...and you don't feel like you've had to hide that because you shouldn't have to...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ...it's ... it, you know, you should be proud of...

NO: Like I know people in the A.A. would have said to me, you know, to move on with your life you've to forget your past and everything. And I just think it's part of my life. It's still part of me, and it'll never go away, you know? And there's no ... there's not one day in my life that I don't wonder what he looks like? What is he doing? Like, I went out to a thing one time – there was this birthday and I didn't really want to go out – and I love music and I went to this place and two wee fellas came in, and one of the wee boys came over and sat down and was talking away and the other boy says: "Are you not coming up here for a drink?" But the whole night I just sat and talked to this boy, and it was *name of NO's adopted son redacted* eighteenth birthday and I remember the wee fella getting up saying, you know, "I really enjoyed talking to you. Can I give you a hug before you go?" And I hugged him, and I went into the car and straightaway I thought: 'Maybe this is my son, and I don't even know if it is or not?' And I cried all the way home, and I cried the whole entire night.

OD: Yeah.

NO: You know, stuff like that would just...

OD: It must be so difficult because you know the age and you know the...

NO: Yeah.

OD: Of course, I understand. I think, maybe, there's a difference, though, between ... You said that your friends would say, sort of, you know 'Forget your past'...

NO: Oh yeah.

OD: ... maybe there's a difference between forgetting and just, you know, giving yourself forgiveness and a break and saying, you know, people tried to make me feel ashamed – and I'm not ashamed, and I'm allowed to talk about this, and I'm allowed to...

NO: But I've been so hurt...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ...I've been so hurt all my life ever since. Because even when, like, I was in a relationship with a person, and when someone is really abusive to me I'm nearly holding on to that person and crying and telling them: "Please, don't hurt me." I'm nearly begging them not to hurt me. And I hate that part of me, do you know? I just, I just wish that that part of me wasn't there. But I just know that it all stems from my mother and...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ...my hurting was all about that, and the child. But I do, I just, I nearly go in hysterics.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And then I react really, kind of, off the walls screaming. Like that somebody's looking at you thinking: she is mental. She's not right.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Do you know? And I know that I'm not one bit stupid at all...

OD: No.

NO: ... do you know? But it's like ... I suppose my mother put me down a lot in my life, and when somebody does that – or is real controlling, or putting you down – it makes me feel so small. It makes me lose myself, as it were.

OD: Yeah, of course.

NO: I just feel as if I'm that wee, lost, frightened person...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... all the time. And even though I went to counselling and shared all that stuff – I still feel the same. You know? That part of me just can't really be changed at all.

OD: Yeah. I can see ... But, you know, things like abusive relationships and things like that, you know...

NO: But I would nearly have stayed in abusive relationships because...

OD: You should forgive yourself for that because it seems, it seems that of course you cling to that – of course you cling to anyone who shows you affection at some point and then doesn't, you know?

NO: Yeah.

OD: That's, that's...

NO: I don't understand people, you see, if someone said they loved you and then they hurt you, maybe, six months down the line, or whatever. I don't understand.

OD: No. I mean it's not, it's not normal behaviour and you don't have to understand it?

NO: And then I think I blame myself...

OD: But it's not you...

NO: ... instead of looking, you know, and saying ... I would know, I'd have a world full of knowledge where I'd know that this isn't about me, it's about the other person – but it's my reactions make me look like ... crazy.

OD: However you react to that is normal, because that behaviour isn't normal?

NO: Yeah.

OD: So it doesn't, you know, whatever you do, you need to forgive yourself for it – because the behaviour you're reacting to isn't normal? If someone's abusive, that isn't normal behaviour. So however you react is rational, because ...

NO: See, I, would know, when I would then be apologising to the ... that person, that person that has hurt me, and I'd say: "Look, I'm sorry, I just hate emotional pain and I've had a lot of hurt in my life and I don't react good". And I start explaining...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ...to the person that has hurt me...

OD: Who isn't acting in a rational way either? So that's not ... yeah.

NO: And I know that that had always come up in my life. And I know, too, that when I'm on my own I'm a far stronger person, and maybe it's because I'm too afraid of getting hurt?

OD: And do you think, do you think you're better on your own for now? Or do you want ...

NO: Oh, I think, I think it'd be lovely to have somebody in your life that would just appreciate you for what you are, and have that respect for you and all. But ... I think since the child was adopted, I don't really believe that I've ever had that in my life. You know I've had, maybe, oh ... After I split up with the child's father I met someone. Never stayed in the house to meet him, went to the pub with my friend, you know? And he was drinker and I suppose I was attracted to that? Thinking this is somebody that I like. And I swear to God, we would've fought, killed the other, when we were drinking ...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... and fought. When we weren't drinking we were grand.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And all that. And I got engaged to him after a couple of years and never slept with him. Went with him for two-and-a-half years and never, ever slept with him, and afraid that I'd get pregnant. Afraid of everything, and not really telling him anything. I just stayed with him, like, for maybe seven years altogether. But it was so abusive, like. Oh my God, and the beatings that he would have give me and I would've like ... One time I was out with him on my son's birthday – that child – and I was in the pub and I was drinking and drinking and I just broke the glass and I stuck it in my arm, and I cut my whole arm, and sure I ended up in *hospital redacted* that time too. It's just ... probably all real destructive behaviour...

OD: So it sounds like, it sounds like when you're on your own maybe you can focus more on just being kind to yourself?

NO: Yeah.

OD: And saying, you know, I didn't do anything wrong, and every time that someone's hurt me, you know, you didn't do anything wrong?

NO: See, I always ... I don't even know if I blame myself? I re-live my whole life ...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... and the thing that hurts me the most is the child.

OD: Yeah, of course.

NO: And whenever I ... I supposed I learned, you know, that if you didn't talk about the first hurt in your life, you wouldn't be able to cope with life? And I remember going to my mother and thinking I'm going to talk to her about this baby.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And being really, really frightened – because I was more afraid of hurting her than hurting myself.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And ... because I remember when I stopped drinking and she invited me and the two children out to her house, and she hugged me and she said she loved me and ... She might as well have been hugging that table, you know? I just had so frozen emotions. I didn't believe that she loved me at all. I found it really, really difficult. But, yet, I would have always been a person that if I thought if I could do good for someone ...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... I would do it.

OD: Well that's what it says in here [referring to notes written about NO when she was in the mother and baby home]. It says you were very kind.

NO: I would've brought my mum out to my house every Christmas ...

OD: Yeah.

NO: ... from when I stopped drinking. And she died in *date redacted*. And, you know, my neighbour said: “Oh, I don’t think the wake will be in *NO’s* house.” But I did, I did the wake, the funeral, everything. And I remember a part of me whenever ... I dunno ... I suppose it’s true that you don’t really miss people out of your life ‘til they’re gone. But I remember all mummy’s – or, my sister’s children – and they were all writing notes, you know, to put in the coffin? And I remember going outside and crying when I saw the hearse coming down the street, just ... yeah. Within my room, I wrote a note and I said: ‘When you meet daddy and *brother’s name redacted* up in heaven, can you just please send me *name of adopted son* back.’ And I was crying my eyes out. But I never, ever told anyone about it ‘til I told my sister there a couple of months ago, you know? ‘Cos it’s always ... it’s just like, I feel heartbroken all the time.

OD: Yeah.

NO: And I know that there wouldn’t be one thing that I wouldn’t do for my children that I have. But I struggle with that part of my life.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Big time, like.

OD: I can’t ... I’m ... You said it earlier, I can empathise but you’re right – there’s something that only people who’ve been through what you’ve been through can understand? But I would just say that I would hope that you would look at the fact that you raised two children who are devoted to you, and love you, and know that that was an amazing thing that you did? And everything bad

that's happened to you, from the age of sixteen, you've come through it and that's incredible. I mean, to stop drinking for eighteen years – even if you had one slip-up – that's amazing, you know? To come through cancer, that's amazing. To raise two children, that's amazing. And you've been let down a lot, and I know that there's this one thing that you really want and I hope – I really hope – that it happens for you. And I hope that you'll just give yourself, I don't know, the credit that you deserve for what you have done. Do you know what I mean?

NO: Yeah.

OD: That's what I would think of most is, is what you've come through in your story is amazing. And, I mean, you aren't alone – there are women who've been through similar things who would probably love to meet you and talk to you about this kind of thing.

NO: Yeah.

OD: I'll give you a message afterwards, but ... I just think, yeah, you deserve that credit for what you have managed to do, and to recognise that you were let down – and you were let down a lot. Yeah.

NO: I think my whole life's just been being let down.

OD: But you've done amazing things through it. And your kids should be a massive reflection of that. The fact that you said your daughter's your best friend and your son's...

NO: Because she has got into habits like with drink over the years and different things. She's *age redacted* and every time her father would ring me up and he'd say: "What the frig is she doing now?" All of the time I've stood by her.

OD: Yeah, good.

NO: You know? I just think ...

OD: Because you ...

NO: ... I didn't do everything right in my life.

OD: No, and people didn't stand by you – so of course you're going to stand by them. And that's a huge part of why you're clearly an excellent mother. But it's to do with the fact that, you know, someone didn't stand up for you. And, so, obviously you're gonna do that for her. Yeah.

NO: But I remember that time I drank – I was with this man, and we were going with each other, and he knew I'd came through cancer and I'd said to him: "You know, you were nicer to me when I was ill than you are now?" He wasn't there when I actually went through chemotherapy and stuff? But I'd known him a long time in my life, and I said, do you know, honest to god I would look at him and say: "Maybe I should have just died and I wouldn't had to have suffered all this stuff now?" And he'd say: "Why are you saying that?" Because, like, he threw me out of the car one night and took my phone and everything and I just felt ... So many times in my life I've just felt like this lost child. So many times. And I know I'm not that lost child anymore, but I still drift back to how I felt then.

OD: Because you were a lost child and you were traumatised. And you were given, you know, you weren't given the help that you wanted or needed and ... I dunno. I think you've done amazingly well to come through it, but of course you feel that way. Yeah. I'm really aware that ... I don't want to keep pushing because I think you've told me so much already and I don't want to keep recording, because I think you're...

NO: No, it's OK. It's alright.

OD: ... but do you have anything else that you'd like to say? Do you have anything that you'd like to say to the people who ... So, obviously, we're doing this kind of investigation, we record these stories, and we give them to the Department of Health – and they decide whether or not there needs to be, sort of, further inquiries into this. And, I suppose, I just want to give you a chance to say what it is that you would like, you know? Do you want there to be more inquiries? Do you want people to know about what happened to ...

NO: Yeah.

OD: Yeah. So a further inquiry would mean what to you, you know?

NO: I honestly think a lot of the stuff that went on in that place, in *Good Shepherd mother and baby home* was abuse. They just didn't care how they treated people.

OD: Yeah.

NO: Like, they were all young girls that was in there with me. And I'm sure, all their life, it's just traumatised like mine.

OD: Yeah.

NO: A lot of it. Because of all the ... you know?

OD: Yeah. I think that's really valid.

NO: Yeah.

OD: So you think there needs to be more...

NO: Yeah.

OD: ... more done? OK. Well, I'm going to turn off the things, but thank you.

END OF INTERVIEW